

Robert Venturi

After working briefly with Saarinen and Kahn, Robert Venturi (b.1925) entered academia and soon became known as an outspoken critic of bland modernism, and the chief advocate of a more complex and playful, postmodern approach to architecture. Establishing his own practice in 1960, many of his subsequent projects also involved his wife and partner the architect and planner Denise Scott Brown (b.1931). His book *Complexity and Contradiction in Architecture* (written 1962, published 1966) became one of the most influential architectural texts since Le Corbusier's 1923 *Towards a New Architecture*.

In 1961–4, Venturi designed the Vanna Venturi House for his mother in Pennsylvania; though modest in scale, its incongruous blending of a giant broken-pediment façade, big chimney, pitched pop-top roof and ironic entrance arch set the postmodern agenda. The couple also designed the Sainsbury Wing (1985–91) of London's National Gallery, echoing original elements of the neoclassical building in a fresh way (opposite).

